

Emphasizing life skills strengthens an individual's ability to learn, apply knowledge, and ultimately function effectively in the real world.

Reasoning

Life skills are not developed in isolation. They are developed through practical activities that require individuals to use knowledge.

For example, communication and critical thinking can be developed through debate. But to participate effectively in a debate, students must research the motion, understand relevant concepts, evaluate evidence, construct arguments, and respond to opposing views.

Therefore, the practical activity becomes the environment where theoretical knowledge is learned and applied.

This changes the learning process. Instead of receiving knowledge only as something to remember, students have a reason to understand it, use it, defend it, and connect it with a real problem.

The same principle applies to project work. A student developing a project cannot rely only on teamwork or creativity. They need subject knowledge, research, data, and concepts to build the project successfully.

So, when institutions emphasize life skills, they do not have to move away from theoretical learning. They can integrate theoretical knowledge into practical activities, making learning more practical, engaging, and applicable.

But the benefit does not stop at learning.

Second, life-skill-oriented activities train individuals to apply what they know. Knowing a principle and being able to use that principle in a situation are different abilities. Practical activities repeatedly require individuals to make decisions, solve problems, communicate, collaborate, and adapt using the knowledge they have acquired. Through this process, knowledge moves from something an individual possesses to something an individual can actually use.

Third, repeated application of knowledge develops effective real-world functioning. Real life rarely presents people with questions that have a single textbook answer. Individuals must identify problems, determine what knowledge is relevant, make decisions, communicate their reasoning, respond to changing circumstances, and take action. Life skills strengthen these processes, allowing individuals to use their knowledge more efficiently and appropriately when facing real-world demands.

Therefore, emphasizing life skills strengthens not only the acquisition of knowledge, but also the ability to convert that knowledge into effective action and, ultimately, effective real-world functioning.

Example

According to a **2020 study** by Xiandong Li and colleagues, published in the peer-reviewed medical journal **Clinica Chimica Acta**.

A real example of this approach took place at **Hubei University of Medicine in Shiyan, Hubei, China, between 2018 and 2019**.

Researchers studied **122 clinical laboratory medicine students** and randomly assigned them to either traditional teaching or **problem-based learning (PBL)**. In the PBL group, students worked in small groups around clinical cases. They exchanged ideas, identified gaps in their knowledge, searched for the information they needed, incorporated new information into the cases, and rehearsed and performed simulated clinical scenarios.

This process required students to develop practical abilities such as **problem-solving, collaboration, communication, analysis, and self-directed learning** while simultaneously learning and applying clinical and scientific knowledge.

The researchers then evaluated the students through theory tests, questionnaires, and clinical-performance assessments.

The result was significant: **the PBL group achieved better theory-test scores as well as better clinical-performance assessments** than the traditional-teaching group. The study therefore found that the practical, problem-based approach strengthened both students' theoretical learning and their ability to deal with real clinical work.

Source: Xiandong Li et al., *Development, application, and evaluation of a problem-based learning method in clinical laboratory education*, *Clinica Chimica Acta*, Volume 510, November 2020, pp. 681–684, DOI: 10.1016/j.cca.2020.08.037.

Linking

This example demonstrates the exact mechanism behind our argument.

The students were developing life skills such as problem-solving, collaboration, communication, and analysis through a practical learning process. But developing those skills required them to acquire and use theoretical knowledge.

Therefore, theoretical learning was not removed when the institution emphasized practical abilities. **It became part of the process through which those abilities were developed.**

More importantly, the students exposed to this approach performed better on **theory tests**, meaning that the emphasis on practical, life-skill-oriented learning did not weaken theoretical learning; it strengthened it.

This directly supports our assertion that emphasizing life skills strengthens an individual's ability to **learn and apply knowledge**, because practical activities create situations in which knowledge must be understood and used rather than merely memorized.

And this directly relates to the motion. The Government may present life skills and theoretical skills as competing priorities. But this example shows that they can reinforce each other.

When institutions emphasize life skills through practical learning, theoretical knowledge becomes embedded within the learning process itself. Students therefore develop the skills needed to function effectively while simultaneously strengthening their ability to acquire and apply knowledge.

Therefore, **emphasizing life skills strengthens an individual's ability to learn, apply knowledge, and ultimately function effectively in the real world.**